“Guess.”

What terrible game was he playing? She felt that he was a cat and she the mouse. Perhaps if she gave him a number, he would stop. “Two,” she said.

He shook his head. “Much more.”

“Three.”

“You know better than that.” He wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. “You’re an intelligent woman, why are you playing dumb?”

“I honestly don’t know.”

“Are Slavs inferior?”

He *was* toying with her. She would give him the answer he wanted, and then surely, he would let her go. “Yes.”

“Then tell me how many Russian women for one German soldier?” He stared hard at her, his eyes unreadable.

The atmosphere turned thick with tension.

“I’m waiting,” he insisted.

“Four.”

“You want me to give you the correct answer, Rose?”

A trickle of air escaped her mouth like a warning whistle. Over the last months, she’d felt something had been building inside him; she hadn’t known or understood what it was, only the sense that it was terrible and dark and he was obsessed with it. Tonight, she grasped that it had to do with Felix’s death.

“A single German soldier is equal to fifteen worthless Russian women. That sounds about right, doesn’t it?”

She didn’t speak.

“This is where I need your help, Rose.” He kept repeating her name, as though he was entitled to. “It’s up to you to decide.”

“What’s up to me?”

“You like saving lives, don’t you?” His eyes locked on hers. “Isn’t that why you lied to me about André?”

She shrank at the mention of André. How had he found out? Suddenly, she felt unbalanced. He was leading her somewhere that she didn’t want to go. Wet patches gathered on the cotton dress under her arms.

“I know about your secret meetings, that you’re in love with him.” He emptied his glass and refilled it. “But tonight, we must discuss something